BeyondChess™

Complete 50-Week Chess Curriculum

Teaching Guide for Instructors

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Phase 1: Foundations

Week 1: Introduction to Chess & The Board

Learning Objectives:

• Identify all 64 squares using algebraic notation
• Understand files (a-h) and ranks (1-8)
• Set up the board correctly (light on right)
• Name any square on the board

Lesson Content:

Key Concepts: • Files are vertical columns labeled a-h (left to right) • Ranks are horizontal rows labeled 1-8 (bottom to top) • Each square has a unique name: file + rank (e.g., e4, d5) • "Light on right" - bottom right corner is always a light square • 64 total squares (8 files × 8 ranks) **Teaching Tips:** 1. Use physical board - have students touch and name squares 2. Play "square calling" game - call out square, student points to it 3. Practice with "battleship" style games 4. Emphasize that knowing square names is foundation for everything **Common Mistakes:** • Reversing file and rank (saying "4e" instead of "e4") • Starting files from wrong side • Forgetting "light on right" rule • Mixing up similar squares (e4 vs e5) **Practice Activities:** 1. Square identification drills (5 minutes) 2. "Simon Says touch square d4" 3. Set up board race (who can do it fastest?) 4. Quiz: Random square identification **Homework:** • Practice naming 20 random squares • Set up board 5 times at home • Draw a chessboard and label all squares

Assessment:

Student can correctly name any square when pointed to, and can set up board with light square in bottom right corner.

Week 2: Pawns & The King

Learning Objectives:

• Understand pawn movement (1 or 2 squares on first move)
• Learn pawn captures (diagonal only)
• Understand king movement (one square any direction)
• Recognize the king's importance

Lesson Content:

Pawn Rules: • Moves forward only, never backward • First move: can move 1 OR 2 squares forward (player's choice) • After first move: only 1 square forward at a time • Captures diagonally forward (one square) • Cannot capture moving forward • Cannot jump over pieces **King Rules:** • Moves one square in any direction (8 possible moves) • Most important piece - if lost, game is lost • Cannot move into check (illegal move) • Relatively slow but powerful in endgame **Memory Tricks:** • Pawns: "March forward, capture diagonal" • King: "One square at a time, any direction" • "Lose the king, lose the game" **Teaching Sequence:** 1. Demonstrate pawn movement on demo board (5 min) 2. Students practice moving pawns (5 min) 3. Introduce diagonal capture concept (5 min) 4. Show king movement (5 min) 5. Practice both pieces (10 min) **Common Mistakes:** • Pawns moving 2 squares after first move • Pawns capturing forward instead of diagonal • Forgetting pawns can't move backward • Moving king more than one square **Fun Activity:** "Pawn Race" - Set up 8 pawns each, first to get one to the other side wins!

Assessment:

Student correctly moves pawns (including first move option and diagonal capture) and king in practice positions.

Week 3: Rooks & Knights

Learning Objectives:

• Master rook movement (straight lines)
• Understand knight's L-shaped move
• Recognize knight's jumping ability
• Practice moving both pieces

Lesson Content:

Rook Movement: • Moves in straight lines: up, down, left, right • Can move any number of squares • Cannot jump over pieces • Very powerful piece (value: 5 points) • Controls files and ranks **Knight Movement:** • Moves in "L" shape: 2 squares in one direction, then 1 square perpendicular • 8 possible moves from center • ONLY piece that can jump over others • Value: 3 points • Great for attacking and creating forks **Teaching Method:** 1. Rooks first (simpler concept) - Show vertical movement (up/down files) - Show horizontal movement (left/right ranks) - Practice "rook mazes" on board 2. Knights second (more complex) - Draw "L" shape on board - Count: "1-2, turn, 1 more" - Show all 8 possible moves from center - Practice knight jumping over pieces **Memory Aid:** • Rook: "Straight and strong, files and ranks" • Knight: "L-shaped hop, jumps the lot" **Practice Exercises:** 1. Rook maze - get from a1 to h8 in minimum moves 2. Knight tour - visit all squares once 3. "Capture the pawn" with rook vs knight **Common Mistakes:** • Rook moving diagonally • Knight not completing the full L-shape • Forgetting knight can jump • Confusing knight with bishop movement

Assessment:

Student demonstrates correct rook and knight movement, including knight's jumping ability.

Week 4: Bishops & The Queen

Learning Objectives:

• Learn bishop diagonal movement
• Understand color-bound bishops
• Master queen's combined power
• Complete piece movement knowledge

Lesson Content:

Bishop Movement: • Moves diagonally only • Any number of squares on diagonal • Cannot jump over pieces • Each player has two bishops: - One on light squares (forever) - One on dark squares (forever) • Value: 3 points each **Queen Movement:** • Combines rook + bishop movement • Can move in 8 directions: - Straight (like rook): up, down, left, right - Diagonal (like bishop): all 4 diagonals • Most powerful piece • Value: 9 points • Worth protecting! **Color-Bound Concept:** Important: If bishop starts on light square, it NEVER touches dark squares (and vice versa). This is crucial for strategy! **Teaching Progression:** 1. Bishop movement demonstration (10 min) - Show diagonal lines on board - Explain color restriction - Practice bishop movement 2. Queen power demonstration (10 min) - Show queen = rook + bishop - Demonstrate all 8 directions - Emphasize queen's value 3. Practice exercises (10 min) **Quick Reference:** • Bishop: "Diagonal dancer, stays on color" • Queen: "Rook plus bishop, chess superstar" **Practice Games:** 1. "Bishop race" - get from corner to opposite corner 2. "Queen hunt" - queen vs pawns 3. "Piece identification" - name piece and its moves **Common Mistakes:** • Bishop

moving on straight lines • Thinking bishop can change square color • Overusing queen early in game • Not protecting the queen

Assessment:

Student correctly moves all major pieces and understands queen's combined power.

Week 5: Special Moves

Learning Objectives:

• Understand castling (kingside and queenside)
• Learn en passant pawn capture
• Master pawn promotion
• Know when special moves are legal

Lesson Content:

Castling: ONLY time you move two pieces in one turn! Kingside Castling (O-O): • King moves 2 squares toward h-rook • Rook jumps over king to king's other side • King ends on g1/g8, rook on f1/f8 Queenside Castling (O-O-O): • King moves 2 squares toward a-rook • Rook jumps over king • King ends on c1/c8, rook on d1/d8 Rules for Castling: ✓ King has not moved yet ✓ Rook has not moved yet ✓ No pieces between king and rook ✓ King not in check ✓ King doesn't pass through check ✓ King doesn't land in check **En Passant:** Special pawn capture! • Opponent moves pawn 2 squares forward from starting position • Their pawn lands beside your pawn • You can capture it "in passing" as if it only moved 1 square • MUST do it immediately (next move only!) **Pawn Promotion:** When pawn reaches opposite end of board: • Must promote to Queen, Rook, Bishop, or Knight • Cannot stay as pawn • 99% of time, promote to Queen (most powerful) • Can have multiple queens! **Teaching Tips:** 1. Castling - physical demonstration crucial - Show both kingside and queenside - Practice moving both pieces together - List all requirements on board 2. En passant - use actual position - Set up the exact scenario - Show it step-by-step - Emphasize "immediately" rule 3. Promotion - exciting moment! - Demonstrate pawn reaching end - Show queen promotion - Explain rare knight promotion cases **Memory Aids:** • Castling: "King moves 2, rook jumps over" • En passant: "Catch them in passing, right away" • Promotion: "Reach the end, become a queen!" **Common Mistakes:** • Castling when king has moved • Castling through check • Missing en passant opportunities • Not knowing you can promote to anything • Forgetting en passant expires after one turn

Assessment:

Student can execute castling correctly, explain en passant, and knows pawn promotion rules.

Week 6: Check, Checkmate & Stalemate

Learning Objectives:

• Define and recognize check
• Understand checkmate (game over)
• Distinguish stalemate (draw)
• Learn three ways to respond to check

Lesson Content:

Check: When king is under attack • King is being attacked by opponent's piece • MUST get out of check immediately • Cannot ignore check (illegal) • If you can't get out of check = checkmate Three Ways to Get Out of Check: 1. Move the king to safe square 2. Block the attack with another piece 3.

Capture the attacking piece **Checkmate:** King in check + NO way to escape = GAME OVER! • King is under attack • Cannot move to safe square • Cannot block • Cannot capture attacker • The player in checkmate LOSES **Stalemate:** NOT in check + NO legal moves = DRAW • King is NOT under attack • But has no legal moves • Any other piece cannot move either • Game ends in a tie (nobody wins) • Often happens in endgames **Key Differences:** CHECKMATE: In check, no escape → You LOSE STALEMATE: Not in check, no moves → DRAW **Teaching Method:** 1. Start with check (15 min) - Show examples of check - Practice three escape methods - "Is this check?" exercises 2. Progress to checkmate (10 min) - Simple checkmate patterns - Back rank mate - Two rooks mate 3. Explain stalemate (5 min) - Show difference from checkmate - Common stalemate traps - How to avoid stalemating opponent **Practice Positions:** • Set up checks - student finds escape • Simple checkmates - student delivers mate • Stalemate examples - recognize the draw **Important Rules:** • You CANNOT move into check (illegal) • You CANNOT leave your king in check (illegal) • You CANNOT castle out of check • You CANNOT castle through check **Common Mistakes:** • Confusing check and checkmate • Not recognizing stalemate • Moving into check • Announcing "check" too loudly (not required!) • Missing checkmate in one move

Assessment:

Student correctly identifies check, checkmate, and stalemate in test positions.

Week 7: Basic Tactics

Learning Objectives:

• Learn piece values (pawn=1, knight/bishop=3, rook=5, queen=9)
• Understand material advantage
• Recognize forks and pins
• Make good trades

Lesson Content:

Piece Values: Pawn = 1 point Knight = 3 points Bishop = 3 points Rook = 5 points Queen = 9 points King = PRICELESS (lose it, lose game!) **Why Values Matter:** • Know if trade is good or bad • Calculate material advantage • Decide when to trade pieces • Evaluate position strength **Good Trades vs Bad Trades:** GOOD: Win more points than you lose • Trade knight (3) for rook (5) = Win 2 points • Trade bishop (3) for queen (9) = Win 6 points BAD: Lose more points than you win • Trade queen (9) for knight (3) = Lose 6 points • Trade rook (5) for pawn (1) = Lose 4 points EQUAL: Same value exchanged • Knight for bishop = Equal • Rook for rook = Equal **Basic Tactical Patterns:** 1. FORK Attack two pieces at once • Knight forks are most common • One piece attacks two enemies • Opponent can only save one 2. PIN Trap a piece behind valuable piece • Piece can't move (or loses something valuable) • Absolute pin: King is behind (can't legally move) • Relative pin: Valuable piece behind (bad to move) 3. SKEWER Reverse pin - valuable piece in front • Attack valuable piece • It moves, you capture less valuable piece behind **Calculating Material:** Count your pieces vs opponent's pieces Example: You: Q(9) + R(5) + B(3) + N(3) + 5P(5) = 25 points Opponent: Q(9) + 2R(10) + N(3) + 3P(3) = 25 points Material is EQUAL **Teaching Progression:** 1. Memorize piece values (5 min) 2. Practice calculating positions (10 min) 3. Introduce fork with examples (5 min) 4. Show pin examples (5 min) 5. Practice finding tactics (10 min) **Practice Exercises:** • "Find the fork" puzzles • "Is this pin legal?" positions • Material calculation drills • Trade evaluation scenarios **Key Principles:** • Win material when you can • Don't trade when behind in material • Trade pieces when ahead (simplify) • Look for tactics every move **Common Mistakes:** • Not counting material before trading • Missing obvious forks • Breaking pins when you shouldn't • Trading queen for minor piece (unless checkmate!)

Assessment:

Student can calculate material, identify forks and pins, and evaluate whether trades are good or bad.

Week 8: First Mini-Tournament

Learning Objectives:

• Learn tournament etiquette
• Understand touch-move rule
• Practice opening principles
• Play complete games

Lesson Content:

Tournament Rules: 1. TOUCH-MOVE RULE • If you touch a piece, you must move it (if legal) • Think before you touch! • Say "I adjust" if just fixing piece position • Once you let go of piece, move is final 2. CHESS ETIQUETTE Before game: • Shake hands with opponent • Say "Good luck" or "Good game" • Be respectful and friendly During game: • No talking (stay quiet) • No distracting opponent • No pointing at board • Think on your own time After game: • Shake hands again • Say "Good game" (win or lose!) • Be gracious winner or loser • Learn from the game **Opening Principles (Review):** 1. CONTROL THE CENTER • Move pieces to control e4, d4, e5, d5 • Start with e4 or d4 as white • Respond with e5 or d5 as black 2. DEVELOP YOUR PIECES • Get knights and bishops out early • Don't move same piece twice • Don't bring queen out too early • Connect your rooks 3. CASTLE EARLY • Get king to safety • Usually by move 10 • Kingside castling most common 4. DON'T WASTE MOVES • Every move should have purpose • Don't move pawns aimlessly • Develop toward the center **Tournament Format:** Round-robin or Swiss system • Everyone plays multiple games • Record your results • Track wins, losses, draws • Awards for top finishers **Time Controls:** • 10 or 15 minutes per player • Use chess clock • Don't rush, but don't take forever • If you run out of time, you lose **How to Handle Pressure:** • Take deep breaths • Focus on the board • Don't worry about winning/losing • Remember it's just a game • Learn from every game **Recording Your Game (Optional):** • Write down moves in algebraic notation • Good for review later • Required in official tournaments • Practice makes perfect **Coach's Pre-Tournament Checklist:** ■ Students know all piece movements ■ Understand check and checkmate ■ Know basic opening principles ■ Practiced touch-move rule ■ Reviewed good sportsmanship ■ Confidence building talk **Post-Game Analysis:** After each game: • What went well? • What could improve? • Did you follow opening principles? • Were there tactical opportunities? • What did you learn? **Remember:** • Everyone loses sometimes • Even champions lose • Learn from mistakes • Have fun! • Chess is about thinking, not just winning **Awards & Recognition:** • Certificates for all participants • Special recognition for winners • Improvement awards • Sportsmanship award • "Best game" award **Parent Information:** • Tournament schedule and format • What to bring (water, snack) • No coaching during games • Positive encouragement only • Celebrate participation

Assessment:

Student demonstrates proper tournament behavior, follows touch-move rule, and completes games using opening principles.

Phase 2: Tactical Development

Week 9: Forks - Attack Two at Once!

Learning Objectives:

- Master fork patterns
- Knight forks
- Royal fork
- Fork + check

Assessment:

Student finds forks in positions

Week 10: Pins - Trap Your Opponent!

Learning Objectives:

- Absolute vs relative pins
- Breaking pins
- Creating pins

Assessment:

Student identifies and uses pins

Week 11: Skewers

Learning Objectives:

- Understand skewer pattern

Assessment:

Student finds skewers

Week 12: Discovered Attacks

Learning Objectives:

- Discovered check
- Double attacks

Assessment:

Student uses discovered attacks

Week 13: Removing the Defender

Learning Objectives:

• Elimination tactics

Assessment:

Student removes defenders

Week 14: Checkmate Patterns

Learning Objectives:

• Back rank mate
• Smothered mate

Assessment:

Student delivers checkmates

Week 15: Midterm Review

Learning Objectives:

• Review all tactics

Assessment:

Midterm assessment

Week 16: Opening Principles

Learning Objectives:

• Center control
• Development
• Castling

Assessment:

Student applies principles

Phase 3: Strategy & Planning

Week 17: Pawn Structure

Learning Objectives:

- Doubled pawns
- Passed pawns
- Isolated pawns

Assessment:

Student analyzes pawn structures

Week 18: Piece Coordination

Learning Objectives:

- Working together
- Rook on 7th rank

Assessment:

Student coordinates pieces

Week 19: King Safety

Learning Objectives:

- Castled position
- Pawn shield
- Attacking king

Assessment:

Student evaluates king safety

Week 20: Endgame Basics

Learning Objectives:

- King and pawn
- Opposition
- Rook endings

Assessment:

Student plays basic endgames

Week 21: Planning Ahead

Learning Objectives:

• Creating plans
• Multi-move sequences

Assessment:

Student formulates plans

Phase 4: Mastery & Competition

Week 22: Famous Games Study

Learning Objectives:

• Learn from masters

Assessment:

Student understands master concepts

Week 23: Blitz Chess & Time Management

Learning Objectives:

• Quick thinking
• Time pressure

Assessment:

Student plays timed games

Week 24: Championship Tournament - Part 1

Learning Objectives:

• Competition preparation

Assessment:

Student competes successfully

Week 25: Championship Tournament - Part 2

Learning Objectives:

• Complete tournament
• Celebration

Assessment:

Complete BeyondChess Phase 1